FREE GUIDE · UPDATED NOVEMBER 2026

Before selling, giving away or throwing out a computer or a phone

A computer or a phone holds your life: photos, documents, passwords, access to your bank. Before it changes hands, four steps.

1. Copy your data

Make a full backup and check that it opens (there's a dedicated guide). On WhatsApp, save your chats too.

2. Sign out of your accounts

- **Mac, iPhone and iPad**: turn off "Find My" and sign out of your Apple Account. Otherwise Activation Lock stays on and the new owner can't use it.
- **Android**: remove your Google account before the reset, otherwise the phone will ask the new owner for your password.
- **Windows**: sign out of your Microsoft account and remove the device from the list at account.microsoft.com/devices.
- Remove the SIM card and the memory card.

3. Wipe everything safely

- **Windows 10 and 11**: Settings › System › Recovery › Reset this PC › Remove everything, and in the additional settings turn on drive cleaning.
- **Recent Macs**: System Settings › General › Transfer or Reset › Erase All Content and Settings.
- **iPhone and iPad**: Settings › General › Transfer or Reset › Erase All Content and Settings.
- **Android**: Settings › System › Reset options › Erase all data (the path varies slightly by brand).
- If the disk is broken or the data is very sensitive, the safe solution is to destroy it physically.

4. Where to take it

- **Donate it**: schools, associations and senior centres can use it for years. I can regenerate it first.
- **Your municipal recycling centre**: taking back electronic waste is free.
- **"One for one"**: the shop takes back your old device for free when you buy an equivalent one.

- **"One for zero"**: in Italy, electronics shops with at least 400 m² of sales area take back small devices under 25 cm, such as phones and chargers, for free, even without a purchase.
- Never in the general rubbish: it contains precious materials and polluting substances.

If you're not sure you've wiped everything, bring it to me: I'll do it and give you a record of what I did.

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